

THE COALITION

The King's Crusade — Module Four

OVERVIEW

The party reaches the coalition's forward camp above Caerwyn and meets, for the first time at real length, the allies marching under Xavier's call: Oksitan and Auberitz troops in numbers, and — approached privately, rather than in camp — a representative of unaligned Norvatch with something to sell. By the module's end, the party has learned exactly what the Promise is worth to the people who marched for it, and has the chance to rescue the first of Elduvaine's captive royal house: a young member of it, held at a lightly-guarded hall not far from where the coalition now stands. Core scenes run three and a half to four hours; Optional Content fills out the rest of a five-hour session and can be cut cleanly if the table is short on time.

ALLIES, NOT FRIENDS

Play Oksitan and Auberitz as genuinely allied and genuinely self-interested at once — neither cynical nor noble, the way real coalitions actually are. No officer from either realm should ever speak for their crown's official policy in this module; what each realm actually wants beyond the Promise is not yet settled, and this module deliberately gives individual named people opinions, ambitions, and doubts instead. That is more useful at the table besides: a party remembers a captain who said something honest over a cookfire long after they have forgotten a stated national position.

Scene	Target time	Notes
1. The Muster Camp	30–40 min	First real look at Oksitan and Auberitz, in numbers.
2. What the Promise Is Worth	45–60 min	The coalition's tension, in individual voices, not policy.
3. Doria Kell's Offer	30–45 min	Norvatch approaches privately. Leverage, not alliance.
4. Sennoch Hall	75–90 min	The first rescue. DC table and stat block below.
Optional Content	30–45 min	Run if the table has time; cut cleanly if not.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

The coalition is exactly as fragile as a coalition built on the Promise should be. Oksitan and Auberitz both marched for their own reasons, which this module does not state, and both are already privately uneasy about how much of Elduvaine's resident magic will actually be theirs to hold once Vale is gone — a doubt none of their officers would say aloud to a superior, and several will say plainly to the party, who

are outsiders to the coalition's own politics and therefore safe to be honest with.

DM Only: the Ward, held at Sennoch Hall, is a real, specific person with no proper name yet — this campaign's royal family is deliberately unnamed. Play them fully: young, sharp, has spent the occupation being quietly furious rather than afraid, and deeply unimpressed by the idea that their rescue is a political opportunity for whoever performs it. Do not invent a name for them at the table if it can be avoided; if a player asks directly, have the Ward deflect ("names are for people with the leisure to be found by them") rather than supply one. Once the royal family's names are settled, insert the name here and everywhere else the Ward appears.

SCENE 1: THE MUSTER CAMP

The camp above Caerwyn is the first time the party has seen the coalition as a whole rather than as a rumor at the edge of the Harrowmark muster: Oksitan tents in orderly rows, their banners a color the party has not seen before; Auberitz's heavier cavalry picketed apart, grooms working in a language half the camp does not speak; Harrowmark's own levies looking, for the first time, like the smallest contingent present.

The camp smells of a dozen different cooking fires and sounds like three armies that have not yet decided how loudly they are allowed to dislike each other. An Oksitan sergeant argues good-naturedly with a Harrowmark quartermaster over a supply wagon; an Auberitz officer watches both of them with the particular patience of someone counting days until the argument becomes his problem.

Let the party walk the camp and meet it at their own pace. If Module 2A was played, Sera Vosk (see her NPC profile in Module 2A) is a natural, familiar face to have turn up here, now properly attached to the Auberitz contingent's logistics; if Module 2B was played, use a new, unnamed Auberitz quartermaster instead, or introduce Garrick Hollow's opposite number for texture. Either way, someone in camp should treat the party as already known — the story of whichever Module Two variant they played has traveled ahead of them.

SCENE 2: WHAT THE PROMISE IS WORTH

Around a cookfire, a council table, or wherever the party finds themselves drawn into camp conversation, individual officers from Oksitan and Auberitz will talk — carefully at first, then plainly, if the party listens rather than interrogates — about what they actually hope the crusade gets them.

"My grandmother always said Oksitan never got the better end of a bargain it didn't write itself," says one officer, watching the fire rather than the party. "I don't know what my king actually wants out of this. I know what I want. A place where my sons don't have to be soldiers. I don't much care whose crown is over it."

Use two or three named minor officers (invent freely — this campaign's Creative Latitude covers minor NPCs without limit) to carry this scene, and let each want something small, personal, and plausible rather than grand: land for a family, a debt paid, simple relief at being somewhere the war has not yet reached their own home. None of them should articulate a coherent national policy, because none of them has the standing to state one, and neither does this module.

DM Only: if a player asks a pointed question about what Oksitan or Auberitz officially wants, the honest in-fiction answer is that nobody at this table — including the officers themselves — actually knows, or agrees. Let that stand as an answer. It is true, and it is more interesting than a policy statement would be.

WHAT THE CAMP LOOKS LIKE

Three armies, and they do not look alike. Harrowmark's lines are humans and dwarves and orcs in mixed companies, unglamorous and quiet, cooking badly. Oksitan's quarter is horse country transplanted — human riders and a scattering of dragonborn house-knights whose armour is better than anybody else's and who are perfectly aware of it. Auberitz has pitched furthest from the latrines on purpose and got it right: gnome engineers arguing over a half-assembled hoist, halfling quartermasters running a supply system that visibly works, and a general air of a duchy that considers this whole war a logistics problem being mishandled by people who enjoy shouting.

Let the party walk through all three. The point is not information; it is that the coalition is a real coalition, with three ideas of how a war should be run and three cuisines, and that the party is about to spend months inside it.

SCENE 3: DORIA KELL'S OFFER

Away from camp — at a well, on a supply run, wherever the party can be approached without an audience — a woman in plain, well-made traveling clothes falls into step beside them, unhurried and entirely unbothered by the coalition's presence.

"Doria Kell, factor of Norvatch," she says, as though the introduction were a formality rather than an offer. "I don't march with your coalition and I don't intend to. I trade with whoever's buying, on either side of this war, and just now I'm buying goodwill. I know where one of Elduvaine's royal wards is being kept. I'll tell you, no charge, no favor owed — because it costs me nothing and it might cost the man holding her something later, and I find that arrangement agreeable."

Doria is not an ally and does not pretend to be one. She trades information the way she trades goods — because it is profitable, not because she is choosing a side — and this scene should make that legible without making her untrustworthy; what she says checks out exactly as she describes it. If the party wants to press her for more (payment for better information, a standing arrangement, anything beyond this one free lead), she will discuss terms plainly, and a DM can use this as a recurring thread: Norvatch as a source the party can return to, always for a price, never as a friend.

WHAT SHE IS, IF ANYBODY ASKS

A party that asks Doria directly what Norvatch actually does in this war gets a straight answer, delivered without a flicker of embarrassment, because she does not consider it embarrassing. Norvatch buys. It has been buying out of Elduvaine for three years, under a written contract with the occupation, and the goods are the kingdom: light-stone by the cartload, Archive material by the crate, worked timber out of woods that have stopped holding their season. Vale extracts. Norvatch moves it. She will say so in as many words if the question is put plainly.

She will also point out, if pressed and sometimes if not, that Norvatch did not open the wards, would have advised against it on commercial grounds, and has broken no agreement with anybody. All of which is true, and none of which is a defence, and she knows both of those things and says it anyway.

DM Only: this is the campaign's quietest gut-punch and it should be played completely flat. There is no villainy in the scene. There is a professional explaining her trade to people who had not thought about where a drained kingdom physically goes, and the answer is that somebody has been buying it, promptly, for three years, and filing the paperwork correctly. Do not let any NPC editorialise. Let the party do it.

DM Only: she does not offer the ledgers here and should not. What this scene plants is that they exist — three years of purchase records, the only complete account anywhere of how much of Elduvaine has already left it. A sharp party will work out on their own what that would be worth to a coalition that does not know how long it has. When they come back for them, the price is in Module Ten.

SCENE 4: SENNOCH HALL

Doria's information is accurate: a half-day's ride from camp, Sennoch Hall — a minor Elduvish manor requisitioned early in the occupation — holds one member of the royal house, guarded lightly precisely because nobody expected a coalition to reach this far this fast. This is the campaign's first rescue, and it is meant to be winnable.

The Hall is quiet in the particular way of a place trying not to be noticed. Two guards at the gate, bored rather than alert; a third somewhere inside, audible before visible. Through a high window, briefly, a figure crosses a lit room without hurrying — someone who has stopped expecting rescue and has not stopped watching for it anyway.

RUNNING THE SCENE

This can be played as stealth, as a direct assault, or as a mix of both — the guard presence is genuinely light, and the module should not force a fight. A DC 13 Stealth (Dexterity) check gets past the gate guards unseen; a DC 13 Investigation or Perception check finds the Ward's room without alerting the interior guard. The three guards are hobgoblin legionaries — professionals on a wage, bored, and a long way down anybody's list of priorities. If it comes to violence, use the Occupation Guard stat block (as in Module 3) for all three — none of them are heroes, and all three will surrender or flee once it is clear the fight is lost.

The Ward (see NPC Profiles) is sharp, unharmed, and immediately useful rather than a burden once freed — she knows the Hall's layout, the guards' habits, and enough about the wider occupation's posture in this region to be a genuine

asset on the ride back to camp, not just a rescued NPC to be delivered and forgotten.

STAT BLOCK

Occupation Guard

Medium humanoid (hobgoblin, or any race), any alignment – SRD Guard, unmodified

Armor Class: 16 (chain shirt, shield)

Hit Points: 11 (2d8 + 2)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
13 (+1)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)

Skills: Perception +2

Senses: passive Perception 10

Languages: Common

Challenge: 1/8 (25 XP)

ACTIONS

Spear. Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. Hit: 4 (1d6 + 1) piercing damage, or 5 (1d8 + 1) piercing damage if used with two hands to make a melee attack.

TIERED SKILL DCs

Easy 10, Moderate 13, Hard 16, matching the tiers used throughout this campaign.

Task	Skill	DC	Tier
Get camp officers talking honestly rather than diplomatically	Persuasion / Insight	13	Moderate
Verify Doria Kell's information is genuine before acting on it	Insight / Investigation	13	Moderate
Slip past Sennoch Hall's gate guards unseen	Stealth	13	Moderate
Find the Ward's room without alerting the interior guard	Investigation / Perception	13	Moderate
Negotiate an ongoing arrangement with Doria Kell	Persuasion	16	Hard

PUZZLES AND SET PIECES

All three of these are the Sennoch Hall rescue, given a map, a way in and a way out. They replace describing the Hall freehand and add no time to the module; the keyed table is there so the DM is not inventing the building while the party is inside it.

SENNOCH HALL, KEYED

The Hall is the campaign's first proper dungeon and it is a country house, which means the map is the puzzle. It was never built to hold anybody and the occupation has adapted it badly: a garrison of eighteen in a building with eleven exterior doors, four of which are glazed.

Area	What is there	What a party can use
1. The ornamental water	A shallow formal canal round three sides. Elduvish. Listening.	It has heard three years of guard-changes. See the puzzle below.
2. The south front	Four tall glazed doors onto the terrace. Shuttered at dusk, latched from inside.	Silent entry, DC 14 Sleight of Hand. Loud entry, no check at all.
3. The kitchen court	Staff who are not permitted to leave. Six of them, none guarded.	Every one of them knows the rotation and four will say so.
4. The long library	Ninian's days are spent here. One guard at the door, bored.	The party's likely first contact. Also: eleven years of estate maps.
5. The garrison range	Converted stables. Twelve off-duty legionaries, unarmoured.	Taking this room ends the fight before it starts, and is loud.
6. The commander's study	Serjeant Hoth, and three years of correct paperwork.	He would like somebody to notice he has been decent. See below.
7. The north tower	Ninian's rooms. One door, one window, forty feet up.	The window is the extraction route and it needs rope.
8. The gate range	Six on watch, alert, with a bell.	The bell is the whole problem. Cutting its rope is a 20-ft. climb.

THE PUZZLE: WHAT THE WATER HEARD

The ornamental canal at Sennoch Hall is Elduvish water, and Elduvish water listens. Three years of guards have walked its edge four times a day saying the same twelve words to each other, and it has all of it.

A character who spends ten minutes at the water's edge – with the listening water spell, the Listening-Trained feat, a flask, or simply by knowing the trick and asking, which any Elduvish NPC can teach in one sentence – gets this, in four different voices, none of them lying:

"Second watch, all quiet." – "Second watch relieved, the tower door is fast." – "Gate to tower, gate to tower, and the bell rope wants seeing to." – "Third watch, and if that dog is out again I am shooting it."

Four true facts fall out of it, and a party should have to assemble them rather than be handed them. The watch changes three times a night, not two. The tower door is checked at every change, so the extraction window is the twenty minutes between. The gate range and the tower speak to each other by shouted call-and-response, so an unanswered call is an alarm. And the bell rope has wanted seeing to for some time, which means it is frayed, which

means it can be cut from below with a thrown weapon at DC 16.

DM Only: this is the first time the party gets to use Elduvaine's magic as a tool rather than admire it as scenery, and it should land that way. Do not summarise the four voices — perform them, in four different registers, and let the players do the assembling. If nobody thinks to try the water, Ninian mentions it afterward, drily, and the party feels the loss without being punished for it.

SET PIECE: SERJEANT HOTH'S

SURRENDER

The garrison commander at Sennoch Hall is a hobgoblin of the Sixth who has held a royal hostage in comfortable confinement for three years, has not once permitted a hand to be laid on her, has filed a monthly report every one of those months, and is entirely aware of how this ends for him.

"I have eighteen. You have got past the water and the bell and I have not heard from the tower in some time, so let us both save an hour. My terms are these: my people walk out with their arms and their wounded, and I will give you the last three years of the file, which is complete, and which is the only account anybody has of who came here and what was asked. You will want it. I would like it written down that the Hall was kept correctly."

He means every word and there is no trick in it. The file is real and is genuinely valuable — it names the collaborator clerks in the Braid, it establishes what the occupation asked the royal house and when, and it is the campaign's first hard evidence that Emrys Ysolde has been talking to Vale.

A party that fights him instead wins. Eighteen legionaries and an optio against five characters at 5th level is a real fight and not a close one if the party has taken the range or the gate. They also lose the file, which Hoth burns, correctly, per his standing orders, in the four minutes it takes them to reach the study.

NPC PROFILES

DORIA KELL

A tiefling of middle years and Norvatch to the bone, dressed for travel rather than for a court, with the unhurried manner of somebody who has never once been the most anxious person in a negotiation. Speech: unhurried, transactional, entirely without malice — she genuinely does not care who wins this war, only that she is positioned well when it ends. Not a spy in any dramatic sense; simply a trader whose stock is information.

Open thread: Doria is a standing resource for the rest of the campaign — a DM can bring her back whenever the party needs information no ally would risk giving them, always for a price, and her price is never coin alone.

THE WARD

A young half-elf of Elduvaine's royal house — which is, like most old Elduvish families, a mixed one, and does not think of itself as anything else — with no proper name yet assigned (see the DM-Only note in What Is Actually Happening). Speech: quick, dry, allergic to being treated as fragile — three

years of captivity have made her precise rather than broken. Speaks of Vale, when she speaks of him at all, with contempt rather than fear.

Open thread: once freed, the Ward is a genuine resource and a genuine person with her own opinions about what Elduvaine should become after the war — opinions that may or may not match the rest of her family's, per the royal house's canon division on that question. A DM can bring her back throughout the rest of the campaign as a recurring ally with real standing to speak for what the liberated actually want.

OPTIONAL CONTENT

THE QUARTERMASTERS' WAR

If the table wants more camp texture before Sennoch Hall, a supply dispute between the coalition's quartermasters — Harrowmark, Oksitan, and Auberitz all convinced their own contingent is shorted — gives the party a chance to mediate or take a side, with no stakes beyond camp goodwill and a good scene.

WHAT DORIA DOESN'T SAY

A perceptive party (DC 16 Insight) can notice that Doria Kell's free information came a little too easily — not a trap, but a deliberate investment. If asked directly, she admits it plainly: goodwill now is cheaper than goodwill bought later, once the party is worth more to her. This does not need to go anywhere; it is simply true, and worth letting the party notice on their own.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

- **How Sennoch Hall was resolved.** Stealth, violence, or a mix — track which, and whether the guards were killed or allowed to flee. A clean, quiet rescue keeps the occupation from learning quickly that Sennoch Hall was compromised; a loud one does not.
- **The party's standing with Doria Kell.** Whether they took her offer at face value, pressed for more, or treated her with suspicion — this sets the tone for every future Norvatch interaction, and is worth tracking as its own thread rather than folding into the road-choice or Calanthe entries.

LOOT

- **The Ward herself.** Not loot in the ordinary sense, but the module's actual reward: a freed, capable ally with real knowledge of the region and a real stake in how this war ends.
- **Sennoch Hall's stores.** Modest — the occupation did not garrison this Hall richly. Enough coin and supply to be worth collecting, not enough to be a windfall at 5th level.

- **A sealed letter.** Found among the Hall's papers, addressed to an occupation official the party has not yet met and has not yet had reason to trust or distrust — a DM's hook for later, not something that needs to pay off in this module.

THE REFRAIN

*By thought, and by word, and by deed,
the king's own chosen kept their creed.
Far from home, where the quiet land lay,
they held the line, and would not stray.*